

Title

Impact of telehealth support on emotional adjustment and coping in family caregivers of residents with dementia

Abstract

Background: Family caregivers experience substantial psychological burden following institutional placement of relatives with dementia. We evaluated a structured telehealth intervention designed to facilitate adjustment and enhance coping. **Methods:** A total of 240 primary caregivers were randomized to receive either the Residential Care Transition Module (RCTM) or control comparison. The RCTM included 6 core sessions plus flexible ad hoc phone support over 12 months. Primary outcomes were depressive symptoms (PHQ-9 score change) and perceived care-related stress assessed at months 3, 6, and 12. Secondary outcomes included caregiver mastery and intervention acceptability. **Results:** At 12 months, the RCTM group demonstrated mean PHQ-9 reductions of 3.8 points versus 1.2 points in controls ($P = 0.015$). Caregiver-reported stress showed similar favorable patterns. Ninety-one percent (107/120) of RCTM participants completed all structured sessions. Qualitative interviews identified key therapeutic elements including validation of feelings, practical problem-solving guidance, and sustained accessibility of a supportive clinician. Higher utilization of flexible sessions correlated with greater symptom improvement. **Conclusion:** Telehealth-delivered support effectively reduces depressive symptoms and facilitates emotional adjustment during the dementia institutionalization transition.